

Is ai actually really bad for the environment?

Posted by u/eb1341985 • 0 points • 10 comments

Or was it made up by people who hate ai?

Comments

u/lreeb • -1 points • 2025-12-19 11:23 UTC

AI itself not. It needs a lot of processing power, and therefore lots of electricity and cooling. The problem is that the companies that offer AI services keep building data centers without regard to sustainability. They don't invest in renewable or any kind of energy, which often drives up the regional electricity costs, and they often use clean water that could be used as drinking water to cool the data centers, and it's not really drinkable afterwards.

u/Boomerang_comeback • -1 points • 2025-12-19 11:23 UTC

If the environmental nuts had not opposed nuclear energy for so long, it would be fine. And we would probably be ahead of the energy curve right now with all the damaging effects of other types of energy.

So it's actually the environmental nuts that are bad for the environment.

But in the end, all of the environmental groups are funded by China because 1) it hurts the economic progress of countries that care about the environment (not China) and 2) Guess who manufactures like 90% of the world's solar panels? And 3) Guess who until very recently had a lock on global production of rare earth minerals needed for all the batteries?

So it's not AI. It's Environmentalists and China that are actually bad for the environment. AI is just the scapegoat.

u/Forest_Orc • 2 points • 2025-12-19 07:43 UTC

The thing is that centralised AI running in large data center using a lot of electricity is bad for the environment, we live through a major "energy crisis", have to phase out fossil fuel as soon as possible due to climate concern, and people build gigantic data center using a lot of electricity, at the point some AI company consider investing in nuclear reactor (which while being climate friendly isn't really "green", let alone managed by a private corporation rather than by the government).

The other thing is the water consumption used for water cooling. A part of this water evaporates in the chilling process and now we have to wait for it to fall at the next rain (With obviously different consequences in Ireland or Morocco)

Meanwhile, due to climate concern, we're asked to turn off the light, the water faucet when brushing our teeth, and have to pay gas 2 EUR per liter because we're too poor to afford an EV

u/sdbabygirl97 • 5 points • 2025-12-19 05:29 UTC

Yes. If you like receiving your information in podcast form, here are some:

How AI impacts the environment (and your energy bill) <https://one.npr.org/i/nx-s1-5551155:nx-s1-mx-5736106>

Could AI Go Green? <https://one.npr.org/i/1250191980:1269288762>

How to make data centers less thirsty: Build them near wind and solar energy
<https://one.npr.org/i/wburwp-1056513:wburwp-1056513-1>

Why are they all from NPR? Cuz they make good podcasts with local news reporters who fact-check and disclose any conflicting interests (which isn't actually legally required, it's just good reporting)

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-12-19 03:15 UTC

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u/DebutsPal • 9 points • 2025-12-19 02:57 UTC

I think if you need to have rolling blackouts in residential areas to support your AI data center, then yeah, it's objectively bad

u/Relative-One-4060 • 11 points • 2025-12-19 02:53 UTC

Increased energy demand, increased water usage for cooling, increased GPU usage meaning more mining for precious metals to make the GPUs, when newer better GPUs come to market, a lot of E-waste is created, etc.

AI, Crypto, and the likes are all really bad for the environment because of how much they scale and how popular/financially beneficial they are.

u/azuth89 • 19 points • 2025-12-19 02:50 UTC

It really is fueling a massive increase in power demand, and that includes all the knock on effects of energy production we've been talking about for decades.

u/Interesting-Lion-818 • 6 points • 2025-12-19 05:11 UTC

Yeah the power consumption is legit insane - like ChatGPT uses as much electricity as a small city just to run for a day. It's not some anti-AI conspiracy, these data centers are literally causing energy companies to delay shutting down coal plants

u/OneFluffyPuffer • 3 points • 2025-12-19 07:02 UTC

1 data center can use as much electricity as a small city. A single LLM may be powered by and perpetually developed using many data centers.